被降级的冥王星

The Planet That Was Demoted



冥王星本身没变，为什么会失去行星身份？

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RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

On 18 February 1930, comparing photographic plates at the Lowell Observatory, the astronomer Clyde Tombaugh perceived a dim dot that shifted between them. An eleven-year-old English girl put forward the name, after the Roman deity of the underworld. For 76 years Pluto held the ninth slot on the planetary roster.

In January 2005, astronomers found a far-off body, later named Eris, at first thought larger than Pluto. NASA briefly called it the tenth planet. The contender posed an awkward dilemma. The term "planet" had hitherto been used loosely, and with more icy worlds likely to be found, a precise definition became a necessity.

On 24 August 2006 the International Astronomical Union, convened in Prague, voted that a planet must revolve around the Sun, be nearly spherical, and have cleared the neighbourhood around its orbit. Pluto failed that last criterion and was reclassified as a dwarf planet, leaving eight. Pluto was physically unaltered; only the boundary had moved.

The vote was valid, yet its legitimacy drew criticism: only 424 of some 10,000 members took part. Hundreds of dissenting astronomers signed a petition. The American Dialect Society made "plutoed", playful slang for "to devalue", its word of 2006, and New Mexico and Illinois lawmakers passed resolutions affirming that Pluto was a planet.

Amid the controversy, an irony was already in transit. New Horizons was launched on 19 January 2006, seven months before the vote, carrying a pinch of Tombaugh's ashes. On 14 July 2015 the unmanned craft flew past Pluto, transmitting images of an enormous heart-shaped plain, fittingly named Tombaugh Regio. The discoverer's ashes swept past the heart that bears his name.

中文译文

1930年2月18日，天文学家克莱德·汤博在洛厄尔天文台比较照相底片时，发现一个暗淡的小点在不同底片之间移动。一名11岁的英国女孩建议，以罗马神话中的冥界之神为它命名。此后76年，冥王星一直占据行星名单上的第九个位置。

2005年1月，天文学家发现一个遥远天体，后来命名为厄里斯，起初认为它比冥王星更大。NASA曾短暂地称它为第十大行星。这个新候选者带来一道棘手难题：“行星”此前一直是个使用宽泛的称呼，而随着更多冰冷天体可能被发现，给它下一个精确定义成了必要之举。

2006年8月24日，国际天文学联合会在布拉格开会，投票决定：行星必须绕太阳运行，形状近似球体，并已在轨道邻域占据引力主导地位。冥王星不符合最后一条标准，被重新归为矮行星，太阳系行星由此只剩八颗。冥王星本身丝毫未变，变化的只是分类界线。

表决有效，但其正当性遭到批评：约一万名会员中，只有424人参与。数百名持异议的天文学家联名请愿。美国方言学会把戏谑地表示“贬低”的俚语“plutoed”选为2006年度词汇；新墨西哥州和伊利诺伊州的立法者则通过决议，确认冥王星是行星。

争论之中，一件颇具反讽意味的事早已在路上。新视野号于2006年1月19日发射，比那场表决早七个月，携带着一小撮汤博的骨灰。2015年7月14日，无人探测器飞掠冥王星，传回巨大心形区域的图像；这个区域恰以汤博的名字命名为“汤博区”。发现者的骨灰，掠过了那颗以他命名的“心”。

“清理轨道邻域”指在该区域占据引力主导地位，并非清空所有天体。英文plain是对心形地貌的概括；译文用“心形区域”，因为整个汤博区并不全是平原。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

perceive v.
察觉；注意到
perceived a dim dot

put forward 动词短语
提出；提议
put forward the name

contender n.
竞争者；候选者
The contender posed an awkward dilemma

dilemma n.
两难困境；棘手难题
an awkward dilemma

precise adj.
精确的
a precise definition

definition n.
定义
a precise definition

necessity n.
必要之事
became a necessity

convene v.
开会；召开会议
convened in Prague

revolve around 动词短语
绕……运行
revolve around the Sun

spherical adj.
球形的
be nearly spherical

criterion n.
标准
that last criterion

reclassify as 动词短语
重新归类为
reclassified as a dwarf planet

unaltered adj.
未改变的
Pluto was physically unaltered

boundary n.
界线；此处指分类边界
only the boundary had moved

valid adj.
有效的
The vote was valid

legitimacy n.
正当性
its legitimacy drew criticism

dissent v.（分词作定语）
持异议
dissenting astronomers

petition n.
请愿书
signed a petition

affirm v.
确认；明确主张
affirming that Pluto was a planet

controversy n.
争议
Amid the controversy

irony n.
具有反讽意味的事
an irony was already in transit

transmit v.
传送；传回
transmitting images

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共31项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

photographic adj.
照相的

astronomer n.
天文学家

dim adj.
暗淡的

dot n.
小点

deity n.
神灵

underworld n.
冥界

slot n.
位置；名额

planetary adj.
行星的

roster n.
名单

far-off adj.
遥远的

awkward adj.
棘手的；尴尬的

hitherto adv.
此前；迄今为止

loosely adv.
宽泛地；不严格地

icy adj.
冰冷的；覆冰的

neighbourhood n.
周边区域；此处指轨道邻域

dwarf adj.
矮的；用于矮行星名称

physically adv.
在实体上；在物理上

criticism n.
批评

playful adj.
戏谑的

slang n.
俚语

devalue v.
贬低；使贬值

lawmaker n.
立法者

resolution n.
决议

in transit 介词短语
在途中

a pinch of 数量短语
一小撮

unmanned adj.
无人的；无人驾驶的

enormous adj.
巨大的

heart-shaped adj.
心形的

fittingly adv.
恰如其分地

discoverer n.
发现者

sweep past 动词短语
飞掠而过

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 The contender posed an awkward _____.

02 Pluto failed that last _____ and was reclassified as a dwarf planet, leaving eight.

03 Pluto was physically _____; only the boundary had moved.

04 The vote was valid, yet its _____ drew criticism: only 424 of some 10,000 members took part.

文章主线

- 发现 1930年汤博发现冥王星，此后76年，它一直被列为太阳系的第九颗行星。
- 重审 2005年发现的厄里斯起初被认为比冥王星更大，预期还有更多同类天体，行星需要明确标准。
- 改类 2006年新规要求行星绕日、近球形并靠引力主导轨道邻域；冥王星未过第三条，改列矮行星，行星剩八颗。
- 争议 国际天文学联合会的表决有效，但约一万会员仅424人参与，正当性受质疑；冥王星本身未变。
- 探访 无人探测器新视野号携少量汤博骨灰，于2015年飞掠冥王星，传回以这位发现者命名的心形区域图像。

参考答案　1 dilemma 2 criterion 3 unaltered 4 legitimacy